

With virtualisation becoming a mainstream technology in most large businesses, 2013 will also see employees preferring applicants who have a fundamental understanding of this domain. And with a vibrant open source virtualisation ecosystem out there, open source professionals will definitely have an extra edge, feels Divyanshu Verma, Linux engineering manager at Dell R&D, India. "Many companies are relying on open source virtualisation to cut costs and enhance flexibility, thus paving the way for more jobs in this terrain. Aspirants are expected to have good comprehension of virtualisation softwares like OpenVZ, KVM (kernel-based virtual machines), Xen, Virtual Box and more," says Divyanshu. According to him, Linux kernel device driver development is yet another skill that may be in demand this year.

Experts believe that the job market is looking up in yet another booming segment--Android apps development. According to Dice Holdings, a job posting website, job postings for Android experts rose up by 33 per cent from last year. Explains S N Rai, co-founder and director, Lava Mobile, "In the last three quarters, the growth of Android apps has been much higher than what has been put on record. So you can understand how hot this trend is in terms of job prospects as well. We do hire developers for our company and also integrate with many small developers to build apps. And this system is definitely creating a job requirement." Industry leaders also named programming tools like PHP, Python and Ruby to be priority skills this year.

"There is also a huge demand for open source security professionals on the recruitment landscape," says Vineet Tyagi, director, GRASS Linux Training and Development Centre. He further adds, "With the advancement of technology, security has become a major concern. A growing number of companies are implementing open source security tools, so the demand for open source security professionals is naturally high. When it comes to hiring, open source professionals have an advantage as they can work in a flexible environment."

So, what skills should an aspirant possess to enjoy a successful innings in companies that work with open source software? Vikram Vaswani, founder and CEO of Melonfire, a consulting services firm with special expertise in open source tools and technologies, reveals, "The ability to learn independently, flexibility and creativity in thinking, the ability to self-manage, a sound technical foundation, and a proven history of open source collaboration or development are some of the skills needed."

Experts believe that the curriculum of most of the training institutes or colleges in India does not provide students the right kind of exposure in open source software and this should change for good. "It's essential to bridge this gap! But for this to happen, colleges should have good teachers and mentors who themselves are passionate about FOSS. There are quite a few initiatives driven by the Free Software Foundation in India to help students who are passionate about contributing to FOSS. Students can look up to these events and initiatives to start contributing," quips Srinivasan.

While Srinivasan feels that the curriculum of open source technologies should be at par with the requirements of the IT industry, heads of training institutes say that they design the course keeping the same point in mind. Dr. D Viswanatha Raju, CEO of Vector India that offers a specialised 'Embedded System Course', explains, "We have a tremendous placement record of 126 MNCs hiring our students from February 2011 to February 2012, and this is because we design the course to be on par with the industry standards. Recently, our students who did a specialised course in 'Android Apps Development' were placed in companies like LG and Sony." Ramesh Kumar, director, Linux Learning Centre, shares, "All our courses are mapped towards catering to the needs of the industry. We keep ourselves abreast of everything that's happening in the open source world and use all this learning back in the classroom. We are constantly updating our course content and developing new programmes to reflect the latest industry developments and techniques."

So, if you want to move up the career ladder in the lucrative open source domain, get armed with the right skill sets! **END**

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